

Review of Ander Egurtzegi, *Metathesis* **(forthcoming in the Wiley–Blackwell Companion to** **Diachronic Linguistics)**

Steve Girard

1. Scope and positioning of the chapter

Ander Egurtzegi's forthcoming chapter offers one of the most comprehensive syntheses of metathesis to date. Rather than treating metathesis as a single phenomenon, he frames it as a heterogeneous family of processes unified only by their surface outcome. This perspective aligns with the foundational work of Blevins & Garrett (1998, 2004), yet Egurtzegi's treatment is broader, more empirically grounded, and more explicit in its theoretical commitments.

From the outset, Egurtzegi states: *"Metathesis is far from a monolithic sound change, but a cover term for many different types of synchronic and diachronic changes."*

2. What the chapter inherits from Blevins & Garrett

Egurtzegi builds on several key insights from Blevins & Garrett: the typological distinction between perceptual, compensatory, coarticulatory, and auditory metathesis; the recognition that some metatheses are phonetically motivated; and the idea that many apparent metatheses are telescoped sequences involving feature spreading and deletion. These foundations remain central, but Egurtzegi identifies limitations and extends the framework.

3. Egurtzegi's new contributions

3.1. Regularity and gradualness

A major contribution is the demonstration—based on acoustic and articulatory evidence—that certain metatheses behave like fully regular Neogrammarian sound changes. The Andalusian shift from pre-aspiration to post-aspiration is treated with unprecedented detail, showing synchronic stages, generational progression, extension across word boundaries, and stable perception.

3.2. Reciprocal metathesis

Egurtzegi introduces a new category, *reciprocal metathesis*, linked to motor-plan exchange mechanisms. This model accounts for full segmental swaps, certain non-local exchanges, and phenomena resembling speech-error dynamics—a domain where Blevins & Garrett lacked a satisfactory model.

3.3. Local vs. non-local metathesis

Egurtzegi clarifies that local metathesis can be highly regular, while non-local metathesis is rarely regular but may mimic regularity through strong perceptual biases. This resolves several ambiguities inherited from earlier typologies.

3.4. Instrumental evidence

The chapter integrates spectrograms, waveform analyses, generational comparisons, perception studies, and fine-grained coarticulatory data, allowing metathesis to be observed in real time rather than inferred retrospectively.

4. Theoretical contribution

Egurtzegi proposes a modular view: metathesis is not a type of change but a possible outcome of several distinct phonetic, perceptual, and cognitive mechanisms. This resolves long-standing contradictions such as regular vs. irregular, local vs. distant, and natural vs. psychological.

5. Conclusion

This chapter is a major update to the theory of metathesis. It extends Blevins & Garrett but also stabilizes the typology, demonstrates the possibility of regularity, broadens the explanatory range, and documents modern cases with unprecedented instrumental precision. For diachronic research—and especially for Pre-Basque analyses—this chapter becomes an essential reference.

References

- Blevins, Juliette & Andrew Garrett. 1998. “The origins of consonant-vowel metathesis.” *Language* 74: 508–556.
- Blevins, Juliette & Andrew Garrett. 2004. “The evolution of metathesis.” In B. Hayes, R. Kirchner & D. Steriade (eds.), *Phonetically Based Phonology*, 117–156. Cambridge: CUP.
- Egurtzegi, Ander. Forthcoming. “Metathesis.” In P. Honeybone & J. Salmons (eds.), *Wiley–Blackwell Companion to Diachronic Linguistics*.
- Parrell, Benjamin. 2012. “Dynamical account of Andalusian Spanish aspiration.” *Journal of Phonetics* 40: 718–731.
- Ruch, Hanna & Jonathan Harrington. 2014. “Synchronic and diachronic factors in Andalusian Spanish aspiration.” *Journal of Phonetics* 45: 1–17.